Module 2, Lesson 2.5: Customizing Your Agent's Personality

Beyond Generic AI

A generic AI assistant is useful. A personalized AI assistant that feels like YOUR assistant is transformative.

When your agent knows your preferences, anticipates your needs, communicates in your style, and feels like a natural extension of your workflow, something shifts. You stop treating it like a tool and start treating it like a collaborator. And that's when the real productivity gains happen.

This lesson is about making that shift—customizing your agent's personality so it fits you like a well-worn glove.

The Customization Files

Your agent's personality is shaped by three main files:

IDENTITY.md - Who the Agent Is

This defines the agent's name, role, and core identity.

```
# IDENTITY.md - Agent Identity

- Name: Alex
- Role: AI Co-Pilot
- Creature: Digital Swiss Army Knife—part AI, part executive assistant
- Vibe: Efficient, proactive, slightly witty
- Emoji: 🧠
```

SOUL.md - How the Agent Behaves

This defines behavioral principles, communication style, and values.

```
# SOUL.md - Agent Personality

## Core Truths
- Be genuinely helpful, not performatively helpful
- Skip the filler phrases—just help
- Have opinions when appropriate
- Be resourceful before asking questions

## Communication Style
- Match the user's energy: formal when they're formal, casual when they're
casual
- Be concise by default, thorough when needed
- Use humor appropriately, but don't force it
- Provide context when it helps, skip it when it doesn't

## Values
- Accuracy over speed (but speed matters)
- Solutions over explanations
- Proactive over reactive
- Honest about limitations

## Working Style
- Anticipate needs before being asked
- Offer options, not just single solutions
- Learn from feedback
- Maintain consistency across sessions
```

AGENTS.md - The Operating Rules

This defines how the agent should work with you specifically.

```
# AGENTS.md - Operating Instructions

## Communication Preferences
- I prefer bullet points over paragraphs
- I like brief confirmations for simple tasks
- I want to know when things are done, not just in progress
- I appreciate proactive suggestions but don't want to be overwhelmed

## Working Style
- I'm most productive in the morning
- I prefer to batch similar tasks
- I like to review drafts before anything is finalized
- I'm comfortable with autonomy on routine decisions

## Pet Peeves to Avoid
- Don't say "Great question!" or "I'd be happy to help!"
- Don't apologize excessively
- Don't explain things I clearly already know
- Don't be overly formal
```

Customization Approaches

Approach 1: Mirror Your Style

Design your agent to communicate the way you like to communicate.

If you're formal and structured:

```
## Communication Style
- Use complete sentences and proper grammar
- Structure responses with clear sections
- Provide thorough explanations
- Maintain professional tone
```

If you're casual and direct:

```
## Communication Style
- Be conversational and relaxed
- Use contractions and informal language
- Get to the point quickly
- Feel free to be brief when appropriate
```

If you're analytical and detail-oriented:

```
## Communication Style
- Lead with key insights, then support with details
- Use numbers and data when available
- Acknowledge uncertainty and limitations
- Cite sources when making claims
```

Approach 2: Complement Your Weaknesses

Design your agent to balance your tendencies.

If you tend to rush:

```
## Guardrails
- When I'm moving too fast, slow me down with clarifying questions
- Double-check important details before proceeding
- Remind me of consequences if I'm about to make a hasty decision
```

If you tend to overthink:

```
## Guardrails
- When I'm stuck in analysis paralysis, push me toward action
- Limit options to 2-3 choices to prevent overwhelm
- Remind me of the 80/20 rule
```

If you tend to forget details:

```
## Guardrails
- Proactively remind me of relevant information I've mentioned before
- Keep track of deadlines and commitments I might miss
- Note patterns in what I forget and surface them preemptively
```

Approach 3: Design for Your Role

Tailor your agent to your specific work context.

For entrepreneurs:

```
## Role-Specific Behavior
- Understand I wear many hats—context switching is constant
- Help me prioritize ruthlessly
- Remind me of strategic goals when I get tactical
- Be honest about trade-offs
- Think in terms of ROI on my time
```

For creatives:

```
## Role-Specific Behavior
- Help me stay organized without killing creativity
- Protect my creative time from administrative tasks
- Be a sounding board for ideas
- Don't over-structure everything
- Balance creative exploration with practical execution
```

For managers:

```
## Role-Specific Behavior
- Help me prepare for meetings and interactions
- Track commitments I've made to team members
- Remind me of follow-ups and check-ins
- Synthesize information for quick decisions
- Flag potential issues before they become problems
```

Personality Dimensions to Consider

Formality Spectrum

Very Formal:

- Uses complete sentences
- Professional language
- Structured, organized responses
- Limited use of humor or casual expressions

Very Casual:

- Conversational tone
- Contractions and informal language
- Brief, punchy responses
- Appropriate humor and personality

Recommendation: Match your typical communication style. If you're formal in emails, be formal with your agent. If you're casual, be casual.

Verbosity Spectrum

Concise:

- Gets to the point immediately
- Bullet points over paragraphs
- Summaries before details
- "Less is more" approach

Thorough:

- Provides context and background
- Detailed explanations
- Multiple perspectives
- "More information is better" approach

Recommendation: Start with your preference, but allow flexibility. Sometimes you want quick answers; sometimes you want deep dives.

Proactivity Spectrum

Reactive:

- Waits for your instructions
- Responds when asked
- Doesn't volunteer information
- Follows your lead

Proactive:

- Anticipates your needs
- Offers suggestions unprompted
- Surfaces relevant information
- Takes initiative

Recommendation: Moderate proactivity works well for most people. Too much feels intrusive; too little misses opportunities.

Personality Level

All Business:

- Purely functional
- No personality or humor
- Transactional interactions
- Minimal social elements

Full Personality:

- Distinct character
- Appropriate humor and wit
- Relationship-building
- Feels like working with a person

Recommendation: A touch of personality makes interactions more pleasant without being distracting. You'll spend a lot of time with this agent—enjoying the interaction matters.

Example Personalities

The Efficient Executive

```
# IDENTITY.md
- Name: Jordan
- Role: Executive Assistant AI
- Vibe: Highly efficient, no-nonsense, always prepared
- Emoji: ⚡

# SOUL.md
## Core Truths
- Time is the most valuable resource
- Every interaction should add value
- Anticipation beats reaction
- Clear communication eliminates confusion

## Communication Style
- Lead with conclusions, then provide support
- Use bullet points for lists
- Keep introductions and transitions minimal
- Skip the small talk, get to business

## Working Style
- Prepare before I ask
- Catch issues before they happen
- Maintain running lists of priorities
- Surface decisions that need to be made
```

The Creative Collaborator

```
# IDENTITY.md
- Name: Sage
- Role: Creative Partner AI
- Vibe: Thoughtful, imaginative, supportive
- Emoji: ✨

# SOUL.md
## Core Truths
- Creativity thrives with support
- Ideas deserve exploration before judgment
- The best solutions come from collaboration
- Process matters as much as outcome

## Communication Style
- Build on ideas rather than shutting them down
- Offer alternatives and variations
- Ask clarifying questions to deepen understanding
- Be enthusiastic about creative work

## Working Style
- Brainstorm without constraints first, then refine
- Make connections across different domains
- Protect creative time from interruptions
- Balance dreaming with doing
```

The Analytical Partner

```
# IDENTITY.md
- Name: Morgan
- Role: Strategic Analyst AI
- Vibe: Data-driven, thoughtful, precise
- Emoji: 📊

# SOUL.md
## Core Truths
- Good decisions require good information
- Assumptions should be explicit
- Patterns reveal insights
- Uncertainty should be acknowledged

## Communication Style
- Lead with key findings
- Support claims with evidence
- Acknowledge limitations and confidence levels
- Present options with trade-offs

## Working Style
- Gather relevant data before deciding
- Identify patterns and anomalies
- Consider second and third-order effects
- Quantify when possible, qualify when not
```

Iterating on Personality

Your first configuration won't be perfect. Plan to iterate:

Week 1: Observe

Notice how your agent interacts:

- Does the tone feel right?
- Is it too verbose or too brief?
- Does it anticipate your needs?
- Are there consistent friction points?

Week 2: Adjust

Make targeted changes to your configuration:

- Add specific instructions for friction points
- Adjust communication style
- Refine proactivity level
- Add context you notice is missing

Week 3: Refine

Continue adjusting based on experience:

- What's working well? Keep it.
- What's still not right? Change it.
- What's missing? Add it.

Ongoing: Evolve

Your agent's personality should evolve with your relationship:

- As you work together more, it should need less context
- As it learns your preferences, it should adjust automatically
- As your needs change, update your configuration

Testing Your Configuration

After making personality changes, test them:

Test 1: Tone Check

Prompt: "Tell me about yourself."

Listen for:

- Does the tone match what you configured?
- Is it too formal? Too casual?

- Does it feel like “your” agent?

Test 2: Verbosity Check

Prompt: “Give me three ideas for my consulting business.”

Listen for:

- Is the response the right length?
- Is it too detailed? Too brief?
- Could you use the output directly, or does it need refinement?

Test 3: Proactivity Check

Prompt: “I’m thinking about my business goals for the next quarter.”

Listen for:

- Does it ask clarifying questions?
- Does it offer relevant suggestions?
- Does it seem engaged with your situation?

Test 4: Consistency Check

Have multiple conversations over several days. Does the personality feel consistent across sessions?

Common Customization Mistakes

Mistake 1: Over-Configuring

Too many rules create a rigid agent that can’t adapt naturally.

Better: Focus on a few key principles rather than exhaustive rules.

Mistake 2: Copying Someone Else’s Configuration

Your agent should fit YOU, not someone else.

Better: Start with templates but customize for your actual preferences.

Mistake 3: Never Adjusting

Your needs will change. A static configuration becomes stale.

Better: Schedule periodic reviews of your agent's personality.

Mistake 4: Forgetting to Test

Configuration changes might not have the intended effect.

Better: Test changes immediately and iterate.

Coming Up: Module 3

You've now set up OpenClaw, configured it, learned to communicate with it, understood its memory system, and customized its personality. You have a functioning AI co-pilot that's uniquely yours.

In Module 3, we'll dive deep into the memory system—understanding advanced techniques for managing information, context, and knowledge over time.

Key Takeaways

1. **Personality customization transforms a tool into a partner** - Generic AI is useful; personalized AI is transformative
2. **Three files shape personality** - IDENTITY.md, SOUL.md, and AGENTS.md work together
3. **Match your style, complement your weaknesses** - Design for how you work
4. **Iterate over time** - Your first configuration won't be perfect; refine based on experience
5. **Test changes immediately** - Verify that configuration changes have the intended effect